

INDIA'S UNDIAGNOSED HEART

HYPERTROPHIC CARDIOMYOPATHY IS MORE COMMON THAN WE THINK

New Delhi, October 12, 2025 — As cardiovascular diseases continue to dominate India's health burden, experts at **BEAT 2025: Cardiovascular Summit & Awards** turned their focus to one of the country's most overlooked and underdiagnosed cardiac conditions — **Hypertrophic Cardiomyopathy (HCM).**

Organized by **Voice of Healthcare (VOH)** in collaboration with partners and supported by **Bristol Myers Squibb (BMS),** the session titled "India's Undiagnosed Heart: Hypertrophic Cardiomyopathy Is More Common Than We Think" convened leading clinicians, researchers, policymakers, and patient advocates to raise awareness about early detection, diagnosis, and management of this complex heart disease.

Hypertrophic Cardiomyopathy is characterized by an abnormal thickening of the heart muscle. Despite being among the most common inherited cardiac conditions globally—with an estimated prevalence of one in 200 to one in 500 individuals—nearly **80–90% of patients remain undiagnosed.** Its symptoms—fatigue, shortness of breath, chest pain, and dizziness—are often mistaken for lifestyle issues or stress, delaying detection and treatment.

The session was moderated by **Dr. K. Madan Gopal,** Advisor and Head of Public Health Administration (NHSRC), and featured a distinguished panel including **Dr. Upendra Kaul,** Chairman – Cardiology & Dean (Academics & Research), Batra Hospital & Medical Research Institute; **Dr. Anil Saxena,** Director, Cardiac Patient Program & Lecturer, Fortis Escorts Heart Institute; **Prof. N. N. Khanna,** Founder & Chairman, Asia Pacific Vascular Society and Senior Consultant, Apollo Hospitals; and **Mr. Ram Khandelwal,** CEO & Founder, Heart Health India Foundation.

Opening the discussion, **Dr. Upendra Kaul** described HCM as "one of the most common yet least recognized cardiac conditions," emphasizing that most patients live with it unknowingly until complications arise. "It is estimated that one in 200 to one in 500 people may have hypertrophic cardiomyopathy; yet 80 to 90 percent remain undiagnosed," he said. Dr. Kaul called for **routine cardiac screening, imaging, and genetic testing** among at-risk individuals to prevent severe outcomes such as arrhythmias, heart failure, and sudden cardiac death.

Placing the issue within a **public health framework, Dr. K. Madan Gopal** underscored that awareness and early diagnosis are the weakest links in India's cardiac ecosystem. "Many cases go unnoticed until middle age because of a lack of standardized screening and diagnostic pathways. If you don't suspect, you won't see — suspicion remains the cornerstone of early detection," he remarked. He also advocated for the development of **standardized ECHO protocols, genetic counseling, family screening,** and integration of awareness programs into public health initiatives.

From a clinical standpoint, **Dr. Anil Saxena** highlighted the importance of differentiating between **obstructive and non-obstructive HCM** and the need for advanced imaging to detect subtle abnormalities. "Many patients with mild breathlessness or fatigue undergo multiple tests but miss a simple ECHO that could reveal the real issue," he noted. Dr. Saxena also pointed out disparities in diagnostic quality between urban and rural areas, leading to delayed or missed diagnoses.

Prof. N. N. Khanna addressed systemic gaps such as limited physician awareness and fragmented care pathways. He emphasized the need to establish **dedicated HCM centers of excellence** supported by a hub-and-spoke model to ensure accessibility and continuity of care. "Once we identify HCM, distinguishing between obstructive and non-obstructive variants is critical. This requires a multidisciplinary approach across diagnosis, screening, and treatment," he said.

Bringing the patient's voice to the fore, **Mr. Ram Khandelwal,** a heart patient and advocate, shared his personal journey. He recounted how early symptoms like dizziness and fatigue were dismissed as minor issues. "Only about 5% of global HCM cases are diagnosed. Early screening and awareness could save lives. Storytelling is not just education—it's learning through shared experiences that can prevent another person's tragedy," he stated.

The panel concluded with a unified call for **early suspicion, standardized diagnostic protocols, multidisciplinary collaboration,** and **patient advocacy** to reduce the diagnostic gap. Experts also urged the establishment of **national HCM registries,** continuous medical education, and structured patient support systems to improve long-term management and outcomes.

Summarizing the discussion, the experts emphasized that initiatives like **BEAT 2025** are vital in bridging the awareness gap between medical science, policy, and patient engagement. Collaboration among clinicians, policymakers, researchers, and advocacy groups will be key to how India addresses its **silent cardiac challenge**—ensuring that no heart goes undiagnosed.